Badhwar told him that Senior Editor Shekhar Gupta was on his way to Madras (Chennai), so Anirudhya should hang around the ‘North Block’ and pick up whatever information he could about the ghastly incident from the previous night.

For a moment Anirudhya was disappointed. It was clear that he was not going to Madras to investigate. Shekhar Gupta was *India Today*’s senior editor. Naturally he would be the one sent to the scene of crime before anyone else. As Anirudhya stepped out of Badhwar’s cabin, Copy Editor Dilip Bobb caught him. ‘Get me your copy latest by six in the evening,’ he said.

The office was full at eleven. Anirudhya sat at his desk and asked the pantry for a soft drink with extra ice. People usually drank tea in newsrooms, but the culture in *India Today* seemed different. Here people spoke with an accent, were more stylishly dressed and had a chip or two on the shoulder.

Anirudhya tried to recollect what he had been doing the previous night. He was playing badminton with his friend in the CBI, Amit Verma, outside the latter’s Pandara Road official residence. Verma’s wife, Shobhana, had interrupted the game, telling Verma that he had an urgent call. The next thing Anirudhya knew, his friend had changed into jeans and a T-shirt and asked Anirudhya if he could be dropped at the Delhi residence of the chief secretary to the state of Tamil Nadu, T.S. Sundaram. He, a Tamil Nadu-cadre IPS officer, had been called for a meeting.

Anirudhya made three calls while waiting for his iced soft drink. First to a source in Delhi Police, second to another in the Intelligence Bureau (IB) and third to Verma and tried to piece together the events of the previous night. He thought he had better type a story straightway. Around 10.25 p.m. Sonia Gandhi received a call from someone asking if everything was fine. The Gandhis had been preparing to call it a night, and Rajiv Gandhi’s personal secretary, Vincent George, had left for the day. Sensing trouble, Sonia Gandhi immediately summoned George, who had just reached home and found every phone in his residence ringing—the callers were from Madras. When Sonia Gandhi got through to one of George’s lines, he was